Vedanta and the Gita, the message of religion and spirituality as he understood it—was also very much anchored in the real needs of India, of his people at that time and in the future.

Of the many angles from which the social problems of India could be analysed, he proceeded from the religious and spiritual perspectives. Therefore, the Swami founded the Ramakrishna Math, based on the twin ideals of self-realisation and service to the world, and named for his guru, Sri Ramakrishna Paramahamsa. But since a math (or matham or mutth) is essentially a place of contemplation, Vivekananda laid the foundation of the Ramakrishna Mission, also named for his preceptor, as a philanthropic, volunteer organisation to work alongside the religious monastic order to spread his teachings throughout the world. The Mission based its work on the principle of karma yoga, the path of selfless, altruistic service propounded by Vivekananda. Karma yoga preached an ethic of action and doing, not merely of the meditation and reflection that was all that spirituality had hitherto been identified with. Ever since its inception, the Ramakrishna Mission has stayed true to its motto of 'Atmano mokshartham jagat hitaya cha', which translated from Sanskrit means 'For one's own salvation, and for the good of the world'.

Vivekananda undoubtedly revolutionised the traditional image of the Hindu monk, the *sannyasi*, in India by setting the example and making social service an integral part of the *sannyasi*'s life. Initially, after the passing away of his guru, Sri Ramakrishna, he had thought of going on a pilgrimage to the holy places like Varanasi, Ayodhya, Vrindavan, and the ashrams of yogis in the Himalayas. However, after a couple of years spent on such visits, he turned his gaze to the common people for whom the only reality in life was their struggle for survival.

When, around Christmas of 1892, he travelled on foot to Kanyakumari, at the southern tip of India, he meditated on the 'last bit of Indian rock' jutting out into the ocean, on which now stands the Vivekananda Rock Memorial. It was at this juncture in his life that the Swami pondered over his experiences of observing the miseries of the poor in the various parts of the country, which culminated in his 'Vision of One India'. This has now come to be called the 'Kanyakumari resolve of 1892', about which he later wrote: